Choosing between IMPERFECT and PERFECT tenses

- Both of these tenses are used to express actions which took place "in the past". **The tenses are, however, not interchangeable** and you need to choose between them carefully.

- The most helpful distinction to make is the concept of **a one-off "event" in the past**. For an "event" to take place, **something has to <u>CHANGE</u> ie start and finish** (*the door opened*, *I dropped my ice-cream*). It is not sufficient just for it to start (*the door was opening*, *I was holding an ice-cream*). Nor is it a one-off if it happened regularly over an **indefinite** period of time (*When I was younger I ate lots of chocolate*).

- All of the following phrases cannot be considered as "one-off events in the past". They will therefore use the **imperfect tense.**

  - *It was raining* — *She was wearing a black coat*
    whenever they saw me — *he always bought red socks*
    She used to sing a lot — *The tea was cold*
    She was 15 — *He looked friendly*

- All of the following phrases are considered as "one-off events in the past" and will therefore use the **perfect tense.**

  - *It rained* — *She put on a black coat*
    when they saw me — *he bought red socks*
    She sang a lot — *The tea was spilled*
    She turned 15 — *He looked at the lady.*

- The imperfect tense is ALWAYS USED:
  - *to translate* "was/were VERBing" *or* "used to VERB"
  - *to translate* "was/were about to VERB" *(être sur le point de + INF)*
  - *to render a past tense after:*

  COMME (*as*), **PENDANT QUE** (*while*), **JUSTE AU MOMENT OÙ** (*just as*)

- The perfect tense is ALWAYS USED:
  - *to translate* "**was/were**" *when it refers to a one-off event in the past*
    This "event" can often be **a change of state of mind** *rather than a physical event: "When I heard the good news I <u>was</u> thrilled = I became thrilled)*
  - *to translate "***was/were + born***" : elle est née*
  - *to translate a* **habitual action in the past IN A DEFINED PERIOD**
    I did it every day for 5 years – je l'ai fait tous les jours pendant 5 ans

How to translate "for" in time expressions: *for 2 hours*

- There are several words in French that convey the idea of "for". In time expressions, it is very important that you use the correct one.

- First, a rule of thumb. **If in doubt, use PENDANT**. However the rules are:

- For completed actions in the past use **PENDANT**

    - *J'ai regardé la télé PENDANT une demi-heure*
      Nous avons fait les magasins PENDANT deux heures

- For actions which will take place in the future you may use **PENDANT or POUR**

    - *J'irai en France PENDANT/POUR une semaine*

- For actions that have/had begun in the past but were not finished, use **DEPUIS** + either the present or the imperfect tense.

    - *J'apprends le français DEPUIS cinq ans*
      J'attendais ma soeur DEPUIS 20 minutes quand elle m'a téléphoné

How to say "*after doing sthg*", and "*before doing sthg*"

- These two English structures looks similar, but the French equivalents look very different and **do not use a VERBing type structure**.

- BEFORE DOING STHG:

    - **AVANT DE + INFINITIVE**
      Avant de faire mes devoirs, j'ai mangé une pomme.
      Je me suis lavé les mains avant de manger une pomme.
      Avant de NOUS coucher, nous NOUS sommes brossé les dents

- AFTER DOING STHG:
    - **APRÈS AVOIR/(s')ÊTRE + PAST PARTICIPLE**
      Après avoir fini mes devoirs, j'ai mangé une pomme.
      Après M'être lavé les mains, j'ai mangé une pomme.
      Après NOUS être brossé les dents, nous NOUS sommes couchés.

- **Note**: in both of these structures the same persons must do both the actions, and the reflexive pronoun "SE" has to agree with the subject of the verb.